to those nations who have our view of world affairs" was not directed at India. Then, however, American officials heavily criticized Krishna Menon's statements blaming the West for the Soviet decision. Observers in the US wondered if there was a U-turn in the administration's attitude toward India.[179] They awaited a visit by Nehru to find out.

The Key to Asia

On his visit in November 1961, Nehru did some damage control. In the joint communiqué issued, India agreed that the West had a "legitimate and necessary right" to access Berlin. Nehru also publicly called the Soviet nuclear tests "a very harmful, disastrous thing." Seeming to repudiate Krishna Menon, he said that it was "obvious" that Soviet actions were the ones responsible for the new "phase" of tension. Furthermore, he denied that there was a nonaligned bloc and seemed to distance India from other nonaligned countries' statements. Privately, Nehru said to Kennedy, "Nonaligned countries are so nonaligned that they do not agree even among themselves." Finally, on the question of Indian support for a place for China at the UN, he explained that Delhi believed it would be easier to deal with Beijing if it were in that body. The Indian embassy noted that after Nehru's visit, at least the "attacks on our motives are reduced."[180]

The Kennedy administration was willing to set aside its frustrations with India because the president still thought it was crucial to help India succeed in the face of the communist—and particularly the Chinese—challenge. For him, Schlesinger noted, the vision for that country and its role shrank somewhat, but it "remained the key area in Asia" and, moreover, the "most reasonable" of the developing Asian countries.[181] In addition, India's influence meant it could play spoiler or facilitator when it came to US global and regional interests, and there was a sense that India would mostly play the latter.[182] Finally, Kennedy told the NSC in January 1962 that "the independence of countries sometimes causes problems.… We should simply have to live with those difficulties." This tolerance, he asserted, was what made Washington different from Moscow.[183]

To encourage such tolerance outside government, Indian officials noticed that administration officials highlighted Nehru's statements in support of the West and critical of the Soviet Union. The administration blamed Krishna Menon for any differences, portraying him as a loose cannon.[184]